These hands not only destroy, but create

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by AvatarMeka2000

Summary

Catra couldn't stand to look at her hands, especially her claws. These things had done so much awful things and nothing good. Adora is a good girlfriend. Maybe Catra should listen to Melog more often.

Notes

-Peeks out- Heyyyy. I'm back. Long time, no see, guys! Hope I still have an audience that will read my stuff. Inspiration hit me like a truck recently, so here you go. Next month will be my 10 year anniversary of writing fanfics and wanted to get back into it before then. Enjoy :)

TW: Catra's usually grade A+ mental health, mention of past toxic behavior, mention of blood, maybe a panic attack.

I never proofread my stuff, so I'm wrong or miss something, let me know.

When Catra looked at herself, she usually saw nothing good. A person who was ruined as a child and became a monster. She saw a girl who would forever hold painful memories and trauma. Eyes that never looked normal, ears and a tail she wished she could make disappear. Looking down at her hands, Catra saw sharp and deadly objects. Weapons that had been used to hurt the people she loved most. She saw blood on them that could never be washed away. Mistakes she could never make up for or undo. She saw the destruction that she was capable of.

Catra hated her claws.

So, she opted to not to look or think about them. It wasn't always easy. She couldn't help but think about it during the rebuilding of cities and streets. She had to look at her own reflection when dealing with reflective glass, be aware of her own body whenever physical contact happened with Adora or someone else, be reminded of the power of her claws whenever she wasn't careful enough while handling clothing or a delicate item. It was just unavoidable.

She hated it, but couldn't get away from it. She still tried though, and the others were starting to notice it.

———————

"How do I look?"

Adora glanced over her shoulder. She saw Catra standing a few feet away, a hand on her hip, looking at her. Adora's eyes roamed over the outfit of choice. It was cute. Her outfit was a maroon spaghetti-strapped tank top, with black jeans shorts. It matched her gold ear piercings that many Magicats had. It definitely made her eyes stand out. Adora smiled.

"I like it. Looks beautiful, baby." She praised.

Catra spun in a circle, partially showing off, but not wanting to be obvious. Adora would give her the attention she wanted. Catra

deserved it. Catra looked down at her outfit, scrutinizing the clothing.

"Yeah? Nothing that needs fixing or whatever?" She questioned.

Adora snorted. She sat at the edge of their bed, finishing up lacing up her shoes.

"Why ask me and not go look in a mirror yourself, Cat?" She asked, raising a brow.

"No." Catra's face morphed, not exactly panicked, and not aggressive. Intense.

Adora thought her tone of voice was strange. It wasn't defiance, Catra not wanting to do something just to get a rise out of Adora. This was a downright refusal, as if the idea was the worst idea. Looking at her girlfriend, Adora saw a look on Catra's face. The one that said, 'how dare you suggest that. Are you for real?'.

"What do you mean no?" Adora, raisied a brow. "Just look at yourself, you goof. It's a mirror. Not a monster."

Catra scoffed, unable to stop herself.

"I know that." She muttered. "C'mon. Let's just go. Sparkles and Arrow are probably already there. So, hurry up."

Today, the Best Friend Squad was taking a visit into one of the towns. Glimmer had insisted on showing Catra around, claiming that the Magicat needed to get out more and see Etheria. Probably just an excuse to drag Catra around all day to stores and stuff. Adora was on Catra-wrangling duty, according to Glimmer, and Catra's getaway, if Adora was actually being honest. She'd keep an eye on Catra, so if Glimmer was pushing her to her comfort limit, she'd step in and whisk Catra away for a while to recharge. As soon as they met up with Glimmer and Bow, they'd gone to stalls with clothing, cool weaponry, and magical items that Adora wouldn't dare touch. Poor Bow was holding all of Glimmer's bags, though he seemed happy to do so.

Adora had one bag herself slung over her shoulder in less than an hour later, a couple of items she'd bought inside. Adora wasn't one for shopping for pleasure, so Glimmer and Bow were trying to change that in herself and Catra. Was it working? Depends on who you asked. Adora had an easier time buying stuff for Catra than for herself. Adora loved going shopping with Bow or Bow's dads to pick something out for Catra as little gifts just because. Catra, on the other hand.... she didn't see the point of it, but joined their outings in order to make Glimmer and Bow happy, though she'd rather jump off a cliff than admit that.

So here, they were, walking and looking at any thing that caught their eyes.

"It's pretty busy today." Adora commented, seeing that there were nearly three times as many people in the town square than usual and four times as many stalls open.

"It's a special occasion. Some sort of market event." Glimmer explained, waving a hand around flippantly, the details unimportant.

It was sure busy and crowded. People squeezing past their small group, in their own conversations and occupied with their own shopping. Adora nearly tripped multiple times in the past half hour. It was a lot. Catra weaved through the crowd with ease, their shoulders brushing on occasion. Catra wasn't a fan of crowds and was pleased to have brought Melog with them. Melog was held snugly in Catra's arms, clearly excited to be out and about, but content to remain with their companion to give Catra comfort.

Catra tried to ignore the whispers she caught every so often.

"It's her. What's she doing out here?"

"Glad She-Ra is here, keeping that demon in check."

"I'd be embarrassed to bring her among civilized people. No Horde scum."

Catra could keep a could poker face, but inside, she wanted to find the nearly tree, climb it and hide in the branches until they could leave. Seems like people still didn't trust her. Catra had kept out of trouble, following the fall of Horde Prime and the end of the war. She made reluctant friends with the princesses and Bow. Bow's parents had all but adopted her. However, the acceptance of Catra into society didn't extend far beyond that. She couldn't leave without an escort, Adora or a friend. Melog didn't count because people didn't trust them either since Melog was an alien from another world.

Hypocrites.

Catra couldn't blame them for being scared of her. She was responsible for a lot of damage to Etherian kingdoms and towns. Probably killed some people. It's hard, if not impossible to forgive that. Catra couldn't even forgive herself. Recently, Catra had moments when she couldn't even look at her reflection.

Not only because of her hair that was still growing, but just her in general. She'd seen her reflection in moments of despair, anger, heartbreak, on the brink of insanity. She didn't recognize herself back then. Shame would eat up at her every time she looked into her own eyes, every inch of herself.

And her hands. Specifically, her claws. Saz, she hated looking at them. Weapons of destruction, of bloodshed. The same hands that had harmed Adora. The same hands that pulled that lever to open the portal-

"Catra!"

Catra jerked to a stop, coming to awareness. For hating her claws so much, she sure thought about them a lot lately. She'd blanked out. Adora was standing in front of her, worry on her face. The next thing she noticed was Melog. The cat was changing colors, displaying her distress, burrowing their head into her arms, as if hiding.

"Sorry, buddy." She whispered, stroking Melog's head to soothe them both.

"You should tell your mate your worries." Melog suggested, peeking up at her. "She may help ease your burdens."

Catra had thought of talking about it with Adora, but Catra couldn't bring herself to. She felt like a burden already. Maybe she deserved to deal with her own emotions alone. Like it's always been. She got herself into this mess, she'll deal with the consequences on her own. Plus, what could Adora even do? She couldn't fix her shitty mind or erase the past.

"I'm fine." She lied, her ears flattening.

"Cat?"

Catra's head raised at the voice. Adora was still there, looking even more worried.

"What's wrong?" She asked.

Catra focused on petting Melog, lowering her gaze.

"It's nothing." She dismissed, hoping to divert the conversation, "just got lost in thought. See anything you like, princess?"

Adora didn't seem to believe her blatant lie, but luckily didn't call her out on it.

"Nope, though George mentioned there would be a stall that you'd like."

Adora smiled excitedly. It made Catra's heart squeeze in her chest. She loved seeing her girlfriend so happy. Adora suddenly grabbed her by the hand. Catra's breath caught.

An image of blood dripping off her claws flashed in Catra's mind. Catra panicked, yanking her hand away, her hand in a fist to keep

her claws from hurting the other woman. She'd never forgive herself if it happened again.

"Catra! What's wrong? Did I grab you too hard?" Adora asked, looking for any injury.

Catra blinked a few times, looking at her clenched fist. The blood disappeared. Melog hopped out of her embrace, landing at her feet, though Catra couldn't focus on anything but her hands. Her claws. Those fucking claws.

Catra almost wished she could declaw herself. It's be messy and painful, but she'd be rid of that part of herself. She wouldn't have to look at them ever again. She looked up, crossing her arms, fists out of sight, she gave Adora what she hoped was a smile and not a grimace.

"Sorry. You're fine." She assured Adora, not wanting to worry her.

Adora stepped closer, an eyebrow raised.

"Clearly, you're not if you keep spacing out and staring at your hands all the time like you hate them." She pointed out.

Catra hated when Adora was being perceptive. Made it hard to hide things from her. Like right now. Catra looked off to the side, her arms squeezed to her body. Adora was observing her, clearly trying to figure out what the problem was and maybe trying to read her mind. Wouldn't be the first time she'd tried. Silence between stretched on, making Catra squirm the longer it went on. She hoped Adora would drop it.

"Do you wanna go back to the castle?" Adora offered.

Catra wanted nothing more, but didn't want to ruin what was supposed to be a fun day out. She shook her head stubbornly.

"Show me that stall you were talking about. I'm fine." She insisted.

Adora wasn't convinced in the slightest, but conceded to Catra's wishes to drop the subject for now. She turned, sliding an arm around Catra's waist. She guided Catra along as they walked. Catra loved the feeling of Adora's arms around her. She never felt safer than in her dumb, blonde, brave best friend's embrace. Though, if you ever tell her she said that, Catra would kill you. It lifted her spirits slightly, knowing that Adora wanted to publicly show her affection and display a sort of claim on her.

The couple walked past clothing stalls and food stores. Catra was curious as to what Adora had in mind.

Finally, the approached a stall with a woman that wasn't necessarily a Magicat, but close to one. Catra wasn't well versed in all species of people in Etheria. The woman smiled kindly at the two, clearly recognizing them. Or just Adora.

"Good morning, your highness." She greeted Adora. "My lady." She greeted Catra. "See anything you like?"

Catra looked down at the items being sold.

Jewelry. Gold rings, bracelets, earrings, necklaces. And they were all in the style of Magicat fashion.

"Neat, huh?" Adora said, grinning. "George thought you'd might like something like this to wear for balls and fancy stuff when we have to dress up."

Adora's eyes roamed over the merchandise. She picked up a golden bracelet with a sun on it.

"You've always wanted to explore your birth culture more. These are supposed to be authentic jewelry styles made by Magicats."

Catra felt a part of her melt. Adora just had to keep being perfect to her. Did it ever stop?

Adora slipped the bracelet onto Catra's thin wrist. The color did look good on her. Catra had never worn gold before, but Scorpia

had once said that it brought out the colors in her eyes.

Catra admired the bracelet. It was shiny and popped out, grabbing attention.

Attention. To her hands. Her claws. Catra was suddenly hyper aware of herself. She pulled the bracelet off, shoving it at Adora, and nearly sprinting away, Melog cloaking her.

"Catra!"

Catra ran. She rushed through the crowds, panic leaking out of her pores. She just had to get away. Her feet carried her away from the noise and people. Trees and grass soon surrounded her, quiet greeting her. Catra stopped, bending over to catch her breath. The only sound was the nature around her and her hard breathing.

"Why are we running away?" Melog asked.

Catra sighed, standing up. She began to walk aimlessly.

"I just freaked out, ok?" She snapped, frustrated with herself. "It's stupid."

Melog padded along beside her, looking up at her, concerned like always.

"Your mate must be worried about you. She must be looking for you."

Catra ignored them. The pair came across a river. Catra found the sound of the water relaxing. She settled down, bring her knees up to her chest, arms wrapped around them, her tail wrapped around her. She stared at the moving water, lost in thought.

So much for a good day. Catra sighed somberly.

She sat there, letting her mind run free. She felt herself getting more and more upset. A heavy sensation in her chest began to

build. It caused her breathing to quicken. The back of her eyes burned.

Shit. Was she seriously gonna cry?

Catra rapidly blinked away a sudden blurriness. She brought a hand up, rubbing at her eyes.

"Can't believe I'm sitting here, nearly crying." She scoffed.

"I can believe it."

Catra looked over her shoulder so quickly, she was shocked her neck didn't snap. She tensed up. Adora was there, Melog sitting beside her.

"Talk to her." Melog demanded. "You always feel better after talking to your mate."

The little traitor.

Adora approached her. She quietly settled down next to Catra, sitting cross-legged. She didn't say anything, simply looking at the water, like Catra had done. Nothing was said for a while. Adora didn't say anything. She wasn't going to push Catra to talk, it seemed. Catra was grateful. It gave her time to sort out her thoughts. They sat there in silence, not saying anything.

Catra dropped her legs into a criss-cross position, settling her hands on her lap.

"Hey, Adora?" She finally spoke. "Why don't you hate me?"

Adora looked at her in surprise at the sudden question.

"Um, because I understand where you were coming from and why you ended up the way you did and because you've changed for the better now that we're out of the Horde and in a better environment."

Catra shook her head.

"I don't get it!"

She shot up to her feet and started to pace.

"I've done so much terrible shit to you and your friends and the people of Etheria! I literally led armies!"

Catra spun around to face Adora, extending her arms out at her sides for emphasis.

"I killed Glimmer's mom! How do you stand to look at me! I can't stand to look at myself! Or these!"

Adora stood up as well, confusion on her face.

"Your hands?"

"My claws!" Catra shouted. "I've done so much with these. Terrible things! I can't stand to look at them, because when I do-"

Catra paused, feeling like something was stuck in her throat. Her eyes burned with unshed tears. Why didn't Adora get it? Must be because she's good. Catra balled her hands into fists, digging her nails into her palms.

"When I look at them, all I see is blood. Your blood. The blood of everyone I've hurt with them."

Adora took a step towards her, but Catra took a step back in response, maintaining the distance.

"No! I'm dangerous, Adora! I don't trust myself around you! I'm evil! I'm crazy! How can you ever want me?! Me of all people! How can you love me?!"

Catra's chest heaved. She had to keep herself in control, otherwise she'd go into a panic attack.
She stared at Adora, waiting for something, anything. Adora stood

there, not having expected her to say any of that. Finally, she smiled sadly at her.

"Oh Catra. Why didn't you tell me this was how you've been feeling?"

Catra huffed.

"Like you could ever understand. You're a hero. A good person. You're nothing like me. You've only ever done the right thing, or tried to."

Adora raised an eyebrow.

"And you have never done the right thing? 'Cause I remember a certain someone literally rescuing me when I was sure I would die at The Heart of Etheria. Or did I hallucinate that kiss?"

Catra couldn't help but smile at the reminder of their first kiss.

"Idiot. Maybe you imagined it." She couldn't help but tease.

Adora smirked, happy with the snarky response.

"There's my girl."

Adora approached her. Catra stayed in place, letting her. Adora reached out and gently wrapped her hands around Catra's wrists. Catra was holding her hands against her chest, fists clenched. Adora rubbed her thumbs over the wrists, trying to relax her.

"Do you really hate your hands that much?" She asked.

Catra nodded.

"They've only ever destroyed things. They're the worst parts of myself."

Adora stared at Catra, saddened by her words. She released the wrists, instead winding her arms around Catra's waist, holding her against her own body. Catra tensed. Her arms were trapped

between their bodies, so they had to touch Adora.
Adora leaned her head against hers, lips softly pressed against her forehead. Catra closed her eyes, soaking in the feeling. Of being loved and cared for. Adora turned her head, resting her cheek on Catra's head, as Catra rested her head on Adora's shoulder, eyes closed.

"I love you, baby."

Catra snorted.

"I love you too, princess."

Adora began to sway, Catra letting her. It soothed her. It felt very serene, like the outside world couldn't hurt her.

"I'm sorry you're going through so much still." Adora spoke, voice gentle, tinged with sadness. "I hate seeing you like this."

Catra sniffed, refusing to be so emotional.

"Maybe I'm just being stupid-"

"You're not." Adora refuted gently but firmly. "We can work on this. Just another trauma aspect that can be worked through with time and a new way of thinking."

Catra smiled. Lifting her head up, she gave Adora a look of curiosity.

"How?"

Adora smirked. She slipped her hand into Catra's.

"Let's go back to the market. There's a place I want to try out with you."

Adora led them back to town, Catra gently holding onto the hand in hers. Adora could lead them into a volcano and Catra, after throwing a fit about how stupid of an idea it was, would follow her

with all the trust she could give. Adora would never do something if it wasn't in Catra's best interest, so Catra was trusting her as well with the sensitive information she'd given her. The couple and alien cat came to a building. It was built like any other permanent shop in Brightmoon.

Brightmoon art studio

Catra looked at Adora.

"You wanted to come here?" She questioned, raising a brow.

"Yeah. It's always exciting to try something new with someone. George and Lance recommended it. You might like it, I think."

Couldn't hurt to at least take a look.

They entered into the studio and immediately Catra was hit by the smell of paint. The place was a pretty decent size. There were people everywhere, either browsing the store, or actively using stuff. As they walked around, Catra noticed all the different kinds of art forms. Painting, drawing, knitting, sculpting. Heck, there even an entire wall that was covered in paint. A couple kids were gathered at that wall, painting.... something. It was kinda cute. Reminded Catra of Adora's drawings.

"This place is kinda cool. Who runs it?" She asked.

"That would be me." A voice spoke up. Catra turned her head.

A friendly looking, older faun stood there, wearing a paint-stained apron. He approached them, wiping his hands on a rag.

"She-Ra. Lady Catra. It's nice to see you've come to visit my little corner of the world. I'm sure I would remember you two being here before, so I'm assuming it's your first time here?"

Adora nodded.

"Yup. It was a recommendation by Bow's dads. I'm sure you've heard about George and Lance, the librarians in the Whispering Woods."

The shop owner lit up in recognition of the names.

"Ah, yes. George and Lance. Good friends of mine, actually. Small world."

The shop owner suddenly looked as if he'd realized something.

"Ah, forgive me, ladies." He apologized. "I've yet to introduce myself. My name's Galleath. I've been running this studio for the last five years."

Catra looked around the studio again.

"Pretty neat. Do you always let people touch stuff here? Cuz I'm pretty sure those kids over there,"
She pointed in the direction of the kids at the wall of paint, making a mess. "are trying to get rid of as much paint on themselves instead of the wall."

Galleath looked in the same direction and laughed.

"Oh yeah. Don't worry. The paint will come off of skin, fur and clothing with some soap and water. They love to come here after school to just let off some steam."

He began to lead them around the studio.

"We always have workshops every week. Everyone that works in the studio pitches in and guides the workshop."

He grinned, unabashed.

"My specialties are clay sculpting and woodcarving. Would you like to see?"

"Sure." Adora replied, looking at Catra.

Catra had nothing better to do and it seemed cool. Galleath led them over to a part of the studio that wasn't being occupied. There were shelves and stools with small circular tables set up.

"Not many people come to this part of the studio. Not without an employee supervising. With woodcarving, sharp tools are used, so to make sure the tools are being used safely, someone has to be watching at all times. Just in case."

Galleath walked up to a shelf. On it a foot tall, thing of wood. He picked it up, carrying it over to a table, setting it down on top. He turned to them.

"I haven't spent much time on this, yet. It's a new project."

Catra scrutinized the wood block, trying to figure out what it could be. There was no definite shape yet, only vague edges cut off.

"Wanna give it a try?"

Catra broke her concentration, to look at the shopkeeper. Her ears raised in interest.

"Really?"

Galleath walked over to where apron were hanging. Taking two, he motioned for them to take a place at the table.

"Sure. This is what the studio is for."

Galleath fetched two, new blocks of wood, and carving equipment. Getting their aprons on and the wood in front of them, Adora nudged Catra, grinning.

"Bet mine will be better than yours." She challenged.

Catra smirked back at her. She loved a challenge.

"Bet."

"Go ahead." Galleath gave them permission, concentrating on his own work in progress. "Do you ladies know how to use the knives?"

They both shook their heads.

"I know how to use knives for other reasons." Catra offered without thinking.

She clamped her mouth shut. She couldn't believe she'd just said that. What's this complete stranger going to think of her now? A crazy, stab-happy murderer? Catra tried to fix the damage.

"Sorry, I just-"

Galleath snorted, a smile on his face. He waved her away, shaking his head.

"No worries. Habits die hard, right? You're funny. George was right. No wonder he and Lance love you so much."

Catra could feel her brain nearly stop working. They loved her? She looked at Adora, who smiled back.

"It's true." She agreed. "You're like their only daughter to them."

A warm feeling grew in Catra's chest. Good to know she had people that cared, despite her past. They might be crazy for it, but she'd worry about that later. She focused back on the task at hand.
Galleath showed them the proper technique for using the carving knife and then let them try it out. Adora, used to handling a large sword, felt comfortable with the small knife.

Catra, on the other hand, felt awkward with it. The grooves and the digs on the wood were all wrong. It felt strange, trying to maneuver the knife to get the pressure and depth of each carve that she wanted. She grew frustrated, getting stuck at a spot that she couldn't find the right way to hold the knife to get the cut she wanted.

"Fuck it." She muttered, putting down the knife.

She used a finger, letting her claw shape the cut she wanted. The cut was cleaner, more precise than using a knife. Catra smirked.

"Take that, Adora."

Catra had a mental picture of what she wanted to carve. It was like a switch had gone off in her mind. Everything else seemed to fade into the background. The only thing on her mind was the next cut of the wood. The broad shape was made by the knife, but the intricate corners and curves and details were by hand. Catra would use a different claw, depending on how deep or wide she wanted to cut.

This is pretty relaxing. No stress, or worrying about how people saw her. Just getting the wood to look exactly how she imagined it. Catra couldn't tell you how much time had passed. Seemed like only a few minutes, before a voice broke her hyper-focused concentration. Blinking, she turned her head to the left of her where Galleath was sitting beside her, taking in her creation. He was smirking, looking approvingly at her.

"Not surprised you're so good at this, for a first-timer. Those claws are made for slicing and carving things up, and having control over your hands definitely makes the task easier than using a tool."

Catra nodded in agreement. Looking at what she'd created, she couldn't help but pause. She'd made this, using her claws. Catra hands balled up unconsciously into fists. Great, just when she'd forgotten why she was upset.

"Can you give us a moment, please?" Adora requested, coming up beside Catra.

"Sure." Galleath agreed, standing up, I'll be over there. Shout if you need me."

Galleath walked away, leaving the two in somewhat privacy. Catra continued to stare at the artwork, a mix of emotions swirling around inside. A calloused hand wrapped around her wrist gently. Another hand was on her back, going in small circles.

"Catra. Can you look at me?"

Catra dragged her gaze from the work table and up to the other woman. Adora smiled back at her.

"Hey, kitty."

Catra snorted.

"Hey, princess." She retorted. "Why'd you bring me here?"

Adora's smile left her face, a thoughtful look in her eyes appeared.

"I may have gotten some insight from Melog as to what they thought you were struggling with. The fact that you hate a part of your body, an important part of who you are, I wanted to do something to make you feel better."

Catra was surprised. Adora had known what was up this whole time? Sneaky princesses.

"Of course I hate my claws. I literally used them to hurt you." She muttered. "That's all I ever did. Hurt people."

She looked down at her hands, her claws sharp and dangerous. Deadly. Pale hands covered her hands, gripping them firmly. Catra looked up, meeting blue eyes that felt like home to her.

"Catra." Adora began. "I'm gonna pretend you didn't do terrible things in the past. We all did. It was war. War isn't pretty. We all hurt someone. It happened and it's over. It's done and you're safe and with me and you don't have to do those things anymore."

Catra shook her head.

"But that doesn't mean I'm a good person now. What if I never was? What if it's too late?"

Adora shook her head, tightening her hold on Catra.

"Catra, you are a good person. You just did bad things. If you were a bad person, you wouldn't care so much. Bad people don't say that they're bad or care."

Catra felt her eyes watering. Geez, it felt like all she does lately is get emotional.

"I still hurt you." She argued, her voice wavering with emotion. "I hurt and destroyed and nothing good came from me."

Adora raised a brow.

"Nothing?" She challenged. "You didn't actively save Glimmer's life and give yourself to Prime in her place?"

Catra averted her eyes.

"You didn't help defeat Horde Prime?"

Catra's chin was gripped, her head being forced to turn so she and Adora were making eye contact.

"You didn't save my life which resulted in the universe being saved, simply because you loved me and was willing to die with me?"

A tear ran down her cheek. Adora wiped it away with her thumb.

"You are not just a machine of destruction. You're a person who was raised to fight and was hurt by people who should've protected you. You were hurt by me leaving and took that anger out on others, which wasn't ok but you didn't know another way of dealing with it. So I understand. But, you're out of there, you're learning to be better and you can be whoever you want now. You

don't have to pretend to not care and be ruthless in order to protect yourself."

Catra couldn't handle the intense gaze on her with the heartfelt words also being directed at her. She instead focused on the pin on Adora's shirt.

"What if that's all I'm ever known for?" She asked. "What if the blood on my hands never goes away?"

Adora was quiet for a moment. She then looked at the wood carving Catra had done. She reached out and touched it, running her fingers over the intricate designs.

"Look at what you made, Cat."

Catra followed her hand, looking over her work. She looked back at Adora, who smiled at her.

"You did this. All on your own. You made something. Used your claws to create something beautiful. No one made you. You chose to."

Catra hadn't thought of it that way. Catra reached out and nicked the wood with a claw, fixing a shoddy cut. That was better.

"See?" Adora said, proving her point. "You're making something. You're good at it, too. Naturally gifted."

Taking her by the hands, Adora pulled her to stand up.

"You don't just break things, Catra. You create, too. Your claws aren't weapons, they're just claws. Not good or bad, just are. You can do bad things with them, but beautiful things, too, if you choose to."

Catra smiled, sniffling. Gods, she was so embarrassing.

"Geez, princess. When did you become another Perfuma?"

Adora laughed. "Just speaking the truth, I guess. Feel better?"

Catra wiped her face, nodding.

"Yeah. Can't believe you made me cry in public."

Adora pulled her in for a hug. Catra hugged back. She let her hands rest on Adora's back.

"I don't know if I'll ever forgive myself for what I did to you, but I'm glad you don't hate me for it." She admitted.

Adora hummed in agreement. "I could never hate you. I can be mad at you, but never hate you. I love you."

Catra purred at her words, her tail flicking.

"I love you too. Sorry I'm a mess."

Adora pulled back, huffing in amusement.

"Aren't we both? It's why we get along. No one's perfect, anyway. Perfect's boring."

Catra shoved her lightly. She loved her dumb dork.

"Everything alright?"

Both women turned to see Galleath had returned.

"Yup. All good now." Adora assured him. "So what now?"

Galleath shrugged.

"Well, you could leave these here and I could recycle them or put them on display for others to see. I really like yours, Lady Catra. Very detailed as smooth in the cuts."

Catra felt her face heating up at the genuine praise. Adora smiled proudly at her.

"Isn't she a natural?"

"Definitely." Galleath agreed. "Actually..."

He brought a hand to his chin, pondering something.

"Have you ever thought of teaching an art class?"

Catra's eyes widened. Her? Teach?

"There's a children's class we give once a month to the children of the kingdom. We need more employees, anyway. You'd be paid for your time. If not, then you just keep coming here and work on stuff, I can give you discounts on items you buy."

Teach. She'd never taught anyone anything in her life other than Adora when they were kids. Would she be any good at it?

"Can I think about it?" She asked.

Galleath nodded.

"Of course! There's no time limit to my offer. I'd like to see you back here in the meantime, if you like it here."

He jokingly winked. "It's good for business for friends of the queen to be seen here."

Adora and Catra left the studio, their wood carvings in hand. It had gotten late in the evening by the time they'd returned to the castle. After a good meal and showing off their artwork to Bow and Glimmer, whom decided to show them all their purchases, the couple returned to their room.

They set their pieces down by the window sill. They'd find somewhere else to put them later.

Catra flopped onto their shared bed, totally exhausted emotionally, mentally, and physically. She closed her eyes, listening to Adora move around the room.

"Hey, babe." Adora spoke up. "I got you something."

A gift? The surprises never stopped. She sighed, opening her eyes. She could see Adora standing at the end of the bed. Catra sat up, ready for whatever her girlfriend was doing now.

"A gift? When did you get it? I was with you all day."

Adora smirked, handing Catra a bag. Catra opened it up, curious.

"After you freaked out and ran away at the market, I told the person at the store to hold those items for me. While you were working on your carving, I may have slipped out and paid for some stuff at the jewelry store we stopped at earlier."

Catra, one by one, took out pieces of gold bracelets, rings, ear pieces, and other stuff. They were so cool, made to look like a warrior would wear them. Adora sat down on the bed, as Catra looked at the pieces. She picked up a piece of jewelry.

"Try them on." She encouraged.

Adora slipped a bracelet onto Catra's wrist. The same one Catra had tried on earlier. Catra admired it. There was a piece attached to it. Adora clipped the bracelet chain, the piece falling up her hand, to her fingers, rings attached to it.

"It's like a ring and a bracelet in one." She commented, slipping the rings onto four of Catra's fingers, leaving out the thumb.

Catra held out her hand, admiring it. The piece fell nicely on the back of her hand, not too heavy. The jewelry made her black claws stand out, but.... not in a bad way. It made her claws seem elegant, powerful. Beautiful, almost. Complimented them in a way Catra had never seen before.

Catra looked at Adora.

"You're amazing. You know that?"

Adora took her bejeweled hand, bending at the waist. She pressed a soft kiss to her knuckles, smiling up at her. Catra couldn't help but blush at the cheesy, romantic gesture. She reached out her unoccupied hand, poking Adora's head teasingly.

"Idiot."

Adora raised from her bow, smiling brightly. She suddenly grabbed Catra's waist, hoisting her off the floor, spinning her around. Catra laughed, shouting at her to put her down. Laughter and empty threats of bodily harm rang out from the room.

Today was a good day, after all.

So yeah! Lemme know what you thought :)

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